Fiction That Feeds Back: From Non-Euclidean Geometry to Machine Worldviews

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Abstract

When may fiction count as an input to the exact sciences, rather than as their contrast case? We argue that fiction is not evidence but a recurrent, checkable input: four channels — formal, controlled, quantitative, narrative — separate under three checks (temporal priority, dispensability, operative residue), and whether machine worldviews open the reverse channel stands or falls on the same falsifiability criteria we specify. Each channel is stated against its strongest available objection and answered on the record, concessions included. The four channels are each anchored in cases: non-Euclidean geometry as formal language prior to physical reference; thought experiments as controlled fiction under a translatability criterion; entropy as an abstract quantity that entered engineering by formal analogy and re-entered physics carrying a measurable price; and narrative fiction that supplies vocabulary and sets agendas, from a wormhole question to the singularity. A mapping (M1–M5) pairs the hardness criteria of hard science fiction with the falsifiability criteria of AI research claims in a constructed structural parallel — criteria with shared failure modes, one row an import from the pre-registration literature, declared as such — and a four-stage pipeline — setting, formalization, pre-registration, experiment — ports the mapping into a worked method, demonstrated on one engineering-grade, mid-strength artifact at the stated power, with its negative results disclosed in full. The reverse channel is not asserted; an adjudication agenda states what would count as feedback and how it would die. Every claim is stated to be checkable by a third party; the frozen artifacts and full digests are deposited in a public repository, cited at its frozen commit, and the instance's temporal anchor is an author-attested freeze, recorded as provisional (§7.4).

1 Introduction

1.1 From decoration to input

The standard account of the exact sciences assigns fiction a contrast role: it decorates the work, motivates it, and supplies the other side of the line that rigor draws. The assignment raises a question the standard account does not ask — when, if ever, may a piece of fiction count as a working input to those sciences, rather than as their ornament or their evidence? We argue that the question has a disciplined answer: fiction can be such an input, and the conditions under which it is one are statable, datable, and checkable. The conditions are mechanical rather than solemn: a piece of fiction — a formal system built with no intended referent, a thought experiment, a quantity defined over an abstract ensemble, a story — is asked not for depth but for a dated, checkable crossing: it counts as an input when its entry can be shown, and the claim fails when the entry cannot — the question of failure is asked with the question of

entry, symmetrically. Treated this way, the subject admits dated anchors, explicit criteria, and verdicts that a third party can re-derive.

Our subject is a two-way loop between fiction and the exact sciences. The forward direction runs from fiction into science, and we argue that it divides into four channel types — formal, controlled, quantitative, narrative — each documented by anchored cases and each scored on the same three checks (§2–§5). The reverse direction — machine worldviews feeding back into the sciences — is not asserted anywhere in this paper; it is set up as an open question with named criteria (§8), because whether it exists is exactly the kind of claim that can die under a pre-registered adjudication. The business of this paper is criteria, cases, and scores, not celebration. Section 6 supplies the mapping that makes the criteria portable, §7 exhibits them end to end on an engineering artifact, and §9 turns the criteria on the paper itself.

What is being claimed when a piece of fiction is called an input, rather than an influence or an inspiration? Influence is a causal metaphor that no instrument grades; inspiration is a psychological report this paper cannot verify. An input, as used here, is a role in a checkable history: something with a dated form, taken up by a named development, and leaving a residue that can be inspected without the fiction's help. The term is deliberately thin. It carries no claim that the fiction was needed — only that it was there, in a way a third party can be shown; whether that thin role earns the word "contribution" is exactly what the three checks are for.

1.2 The claim, its falsifiability conditions, and the three checks

The thesis of this paper is:

Fiction is not evidence, but it is a recurrent, checkable input to the exact sciences: four channels — formal, controlled, quantitative, narrative — separate under three checks (temporal priority, dispensability of the fictional input, operative residue), and whether machine worldviews open the reverse channel stands or falls on the same falsifiability criteria we specify.

Three delimitations are part of the claim, not qualifications bolted onto it. We do not claim that fiction is necessary to science; we do not claim that science descends from fiction; and we do not claim that the reverse channel exists. "Checkable" carries its ordinary methodological sense: the contribution credited to a fictional input must be confirmable or criticizable by named checks, not by taste. "Decidable" is reserved for the pre-registered tier (§6–§7); the thesis sentence deliberately does not use it. On the historical tier (§2–§5), a checkable claim is one a third party can re-examine against dated anchors, and the D check's bounded adjudicative power is recorded rather than concealed. The paper claims re-examinability for its historical claims and falsifiability only for its pre-registered ones, and the master table (§9.1) is graded to that split.

The claim is falsifiable in four specified ways, and the order is deliberate: the conditions are fixed before the facts are in — the paper's first action, not its last resort — the same order the pipeline of §6 demands of any claim it adjudicates, applied first to this paper's own thesis.

- **F-C1 (typology).** If the four channel types prove pairwise inseparable under the three checks — if the checks return the same profile for types that are supposed to differ — the four-way typology is weakened. Operational reading: for each pair of channel types, at least one scored flagship case must return a differing grade on at least one of T, D, or R; the condition triggers when some pair returns identical grade profiles across all scored flagship cases of both types.
- **F-C2 (channel).** If the flagship case of any channel fails the temporal check — the dated priority of the fictional input collapses — or cannot sustain even the supply-level claim, leaving no operative residue behind, that channel is downgraded. Operational reading: the temporal check fails when the earliest dated record of the fictional input is not earlier than the earliest dated record of the scientific use credited to it; the supply-level claim fails when no primary record of the development carries an operative residue of the input. A

demonstrated dispensable input is not a downgrade trigger under this condition: the channel claims are stated at the supply level, so a fiction-free account of the same development would re-confirm the grading rather than refute the claim.

- **F-C3 (reverse channel).** If hypotheses generated by AI systems, run under pre-registered adjudication, systematically leave no kill line to hang — no falsifiable consequence that a decisive test can reject — then the proposed reverse channel ("machine worldviews feed back into science") is declared dead. Operational reading: systematically means in every case of a sample whose size, source, and counting rule are fixed in the adjudication protocol before the run; a death declared on a post-hoc or moving sample would itself fail the pre-registration it is invoked under.
- **F-C4 (non-collage).** If new cases cannot be classified without ambiguity into one of the four forms under the same three checks, the typology is ad hoc. Operational reading: classification is unambiguous when two classifiers working independently from the case record and the definitions of §1 assign exactly one form each and agree; persistent disagreement, or persistently more than one admissible form, is the ambiguity that triggers the condition.

The three checks are applied to every channel, section by section, and consolidated in §9.1.

- **T (temporal priority).** The fictional input must precede the scientific use it is credited with, and the precedence must be anchorable — by etymology and dictionary record, by primary text, or by participant self-statement.
- **D (dispensability).** An account of the same scientific development that omits the fictional input must be visibly less parsimonious. If an equally parsimonious fiction-free account exists, the channel's contribution is downgraded from necessity to available convenience.
- **R (operative residue).** The encounter must leave an operative residue — a vocabulary, a quantity, an agenda item, or a formal system that continues to do work after the encounter.

Read as a grammar rather than a scorecard, the three checks are one discipline stated in three tenses. T is the tense of the crossing: an input that enters breaks a prior order of what counted as scientific material, and what the record carries is the timing of that crossing — not the fiction's standing, but its date. R is the tense of the response: the crossing is answered by the receiving discipline, and the record carries what the answer settles — the residue left in use — rather than the crossing that prompted it. D is the tense of no-necessity: the checks score an arrival, never a uniqueness, and where the pool carries no evidence either way the paper records the indeterminacy instead of spending it — no silence is converted into a necessity thesis on one side or a dismissal on the other. The order is not decorative: first the dated crossing, then the settled residue, and the no-necessity discipline holding throughout — the order in which the channels of §2–§5 are scored, the order in which the reverse channel of §8 would have to die.

The D check returns one of four dispositions, and the dictionary is stated once here so that every later table reads against it. **Partial pass**: the pool contains positive evidence of non-uniqueness, and the claim is downgraded to the supply level (Channel I). **Unresolved by design**: the check pits live positions against each other and the claim is worded to be invariant under either resolution (Channel II). **Indeterminate**: the pool contains no study that could run the check (Channels III and IV). **Out of scope**: the claim never invokes indispensability, so the check has no target (the §7 instance, whose claim rests on executability). The four labels state different reasons the check stops short of a verdict — evidence of non-uniqueness, a live dispute the claim is invariant under, a missing study, or no target at all — and none of them is a verdict of indispensability; no channel in this paper claims one.

Two evidence tiers appear in this paper and are never mixed. Historical evidence is graded by anchor type — primary-source anchor, self-statement anchor, lexical anchor, named textual anchor, quantitative study — and no historical claim is worded to need more than its tier supports. The engineering case of §7 is graded on the pre-registered adjudication tier, a different instrument. Mixing — a claim borrowing the authority of the other tier — never happens;

porting, in §6 and §8, is a criteria operation: the checks travel and are re-instantiated at the receiving tier's own grade.

The typology itself carries a positive classification principle, not only a residual one. The channels are separated by the form in which a fictional input enters science — a self-consistent symbolic system (Channel I), a bounded scenario (Channel II), a defined quantity (Channel III), a narrative (Channel IV) — and the four forms are distinguished by mutually exclusive, third-party-checkable objects: a formal system's adoption status, a scenario's reconstructible argument, a quantity's formula and price, a narrative's datable textual trail. The one boundary that could blur — scenario versus narrative — is fixed by a translatability gate: a reconstructible argument makes Channel II, a dated-text-and-reception object makes Channel IV, and translatability takes priority where both readings are available. The D check is declared an asymmetric weak test: it can downgrade, never confirm, and on the current pool it returns no clean verdict — one partial pass, one unresolved by design, two indeterminate, one out of scope — a record, not a defect, of a check whose function is to lower claims to the level their evidence supports. Coverage is not a closed result; F-C4 holds it open to a counterexample channel.

In each form, the fiction's mode of not-existing-in-science differs, and the difference is what the checks read. The formal system is an unadopted language: it exists as syntax and does not exist as physics until a theory takes it up. The scenario is an unperformed experiment: it exists as an argument pattern, and what it can be credited with is what the live dispute of §3 turns on. The ensemble quantity is an unmaterialized object: it exists as a definition with a price, not as a thing in any laboratory. The narrative is an event that did not happen: it exists as a text with a reception, and only the reception is checkable. The checks are graded accordingly: what does not exist in the science has to have existed somewhere checkable — as a dated text, a dated definition, a dated dispute — and that is where T's arrows point. The typology is thus not four specimens of one thing but four ways of being absent from the science while supplying it, and the paper's neutrality about which way matters most is itself an outcome of the checks, not a prior preference among them.

1.3 Contributions and scope

The paper makes five contributions, ordered by what the checks can carry rather than by narrative precedence.

1. **A criterion apparatus for fiction-to-science feedback**: the three checks (temporal priority, dispensability, operative residue) with a declared disposition dictionary for D, two evidence tiers with a declared boundary between mixing and porting, and four falsifiability conditions on the typology (§1.2, §9).
2. **A four-channel application of the apparatus**: formal, controlled, quantitative, narrative — each channel an anchored application whose claims are stated at the supply level its checks support (§2–§5).
3. **A mapping (M1–M5) between the "hardness" criteria of hard science fiction and the falsifiability criteria of AI research claims**, with a four-stage pipeline that ports the former into the latter (§6).
4. **One engineering-grade, mid-strength instance of the full pipeline**, on record and examined in §7 on the same footing as the historical cases, scored by the same criteria, with its negative results disclosed in full.
5. **An adjudication agenda for the reverse channel**: what would count as machine worldviews feeding back into science, stated so that it can fail (§8).

The order is itself a graded claim: the apparatus (1) is what this paper would be missed for; the channel readings (2) are its first application and are graded at the supply level by design, and the paper asks to be credited with the checks that produced the grades, not with the sweep

of the channels.

Where does this paper stop, and why say so before the cases rather than after? A reader who takes the thesis seriously is owed the boundaries early: the four declarations that follow are not disclaimers appended after the fact but the edges the cases were built inside. Each answers a question the material itself raises — what kind of paper this is, what its evidence pool closes at, which instruments its claims are graded on, and what its novelty statements are relative to. The declarations and the falsifiability conditions of §1.2 bound the paper jointly: the conditions say how it could die, the declarations say where it declines to live.

(i) This is an argument with an intellectual-historical core; its historical sections are case studies, not a systematic history. (ii) The reference pool is closed: sixty-six items, cited by pool number [R01]–[R66]; pool numbers count entries, not works — [R12] carries two primary texts under one entry because they anchor the same lexical item. Fifty-five entries were verified against primary records; one ([R56]) is the authors' own companion study, anonymized in this edition (title, authors, and identifiers withheld, to be restored in a later revised edition, available to any reader from the author on request) and attested by its authors rather than independently verified. Ten entries were added after the search closed, all by declaration: [R57], a second companion work (declared in §8.4; carried in the public repository at the citation-frozen commit; attested by its authors rather than independently verified), and [R58]–[R66], the instance-candidate additions of 2026-10-20, each verified against primary records at addition — they enter outside the three-line search, and the search-relative statements of (iv) are unaffected. Batch-by-batch verification records for the pool are consolidated in the Appendix. (iii) The historical evidence tier and the pre-registered adjudication tier are distinct instruments (§1.2); nothing in the historical sections borrows the authority of the latter. (iv) Uniqueness-flavored statements — including the statement that no integrated treatment of the four channels exists — are made strictly relative to our three-line search, completed 2026-09-16; its protocol and limits are stated in the Appendix and inherited by every statement made relative to it. The closest dialogue partner that search returned [R42] works a comparative taxonomy of fiction's roles; it carries neither a four-channel typology with scored cases nor an adjudication mechanism, so the two projects are complementary rather than competing.

A note on numbers: every number in this paper is bibliographic, a formula named in the text, or an experimental number cited by field path into the frozen record examined in §7. The term "machine worldview" appears as in the thesis sentence; its definitional anchor is cited in §8.

2 Channel I: Formal Fiction into Physics

Why does the typology begin here? The formal channel is the limiting case in which the fiction is purest — a system with no referent, no scenario, no claims about anything — and therefore the hardest case for the idea that fiction can do scientific work. If a language with no intended subject matter can be shown to have carried physics, the loop closes in its barest form; if it cannot, the idea retreats to the softer forms and must survive there. Channel I is where fiction-as-input has the least cover, and it opens the typology for that reason.

2.1 The historical chain

A geometry can be built before there is anything for it to describe. The nineteenth century produced consistent alternatives to Euclidean geometry as pure formal constructions: at the time of their construction no physical theory made use of them. The physical speculation is quoted and dated. In the habilitation lecture, Riemann makes the properties distinguishing space a matter "only to be deduced from experience," seeks the ground of spatial metric relations outside space, "in binding forces which act upon it," and hands the open end to "the domain

of another science, of physic" [R53]. Clifford proposed that the variation of the curvature of space is "what really happens in that phenomenon which we call the motion of matter" [R54]. Helmholtz made the public case for the empirical standing of geometrical axioms: on the empirical hypothesis, axioms "can be inferred from facts of experience and so established, or if, when tested by experience, they are perhaps to be rejected"; measurements that "confirm empirically the axiom of parallels" leave the measure of curvature of our space "thus far to be indistinguishable from zero," and whether it is exactly zero "remains, however, a question" [R55]. Yet this remained speculation, never an adopted physical theory: they were languages in search of a subject matter. We use "formal fiction" in exactly this sense — a self-consistent symbolic system not adopted, and not coordinated, as the language of any physical theory at the time of its construction — and not as a rhetorical flourish. The constructors' speculation is recorded, not erased, but no physical theory took it up, and that is the distinction the definition draws; it makes the channel's input state checkable by a datable historical question.

How one such language was taken up by physics is documented in detail by Walter [R01]: Minkowski's four-dimensional reformulation of special relativity carried a recognizably non-Euclidean style, and the style was itself part of what was transmitted — not the mathematics alone, but a way of writing, teaching, and receiving relativity, treated by Walter as a historiographical object in its own right. The chain continues through general relativity, whose formulation took Riemannian geometry as its working language. By then the direction of travel was fixed: a formal apparatus originally developed with no physical referent had become the standard medium in which a physical theory was stated; the geometry did not need the physics to be consistent, and the physics arrived later and found the language available.

That order — the language precedes the empirical joining — is the signature of this channel, and unlike most signatures in intellectual history it is anchorable in primary texts: the constructions, the reformulation, and the participant's account of the join all carry dates. Channel I is presented first as the template for what an anchored channel looks like, not as the strongest claim the paper makes.

2.2 The join, in the participant's testimony

Einstein's 1921 lecture "Geometry and Experience", published the following year [R02], is the participant testimony for how the join was made. Einstein's account separates pure geometry — a formal system whose certainty holds precisely insofar as it abstains from reference to reality — from applied geometry, which acquires empirical content through a stipulated coordination between formal terms and physical situations. Certainty and reference are, on this account, a trade. In general relativity the trade is carried by the field laws together with the geometry: the coordination is an act performed inside physics, not a property waiting inside the fiction to be discovered.

For the channel this fixes the temporal order — the formal system precedes the coordination — and the division of labor: the fictional input supplies structure, the physical commitment is added later by the person best placed to know, with the join carrying a participant account. It also explains why the channel's residue is a language rather than a fact: the empirical content lives in the coordination, not in the geometry.

Wigner's "unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics in the natural sciences" [R03] names the residual surprise of the pattern; we use it as the channel's counter-question, not its explanation — it records that something is unexplained after the anchors are laid, and the channel claim below spends no more than the anchors support.

2.3 Channel claim and assessment

Channel claim. Formal fiction supplies self-consistent language prior to reference, and the feedback occurs as language preceding the empirical joining.

Channel assessment.

- *T (temporal priority).* The formal structures precede their physical deployment: the constructions predate the uses, the transmission of the non-Euclidean style into physics is documented in the scholarly record [R01], and the join is fixed by the participant's own account [R02]. Every link is primary-text anchorable. **Pass.**
- *D (dispensability).* Here the channel is deliberately graded down, and the scholarship says so: Walter's study shows the non-Euclidean style was not the unique path into relativity — one presentation among available alternatives, adopted for reasons that include notation and pedagogy as much as necessity [R01]. The check therefore downgrades the claim from necessity to supply: the fictional language was available, adopted, and consequential — not indispensable. This is the check doing its job: it prevents the channel claim from drifting into a necessity thesis. **Partial pass; the claim is stated at the supply level.**
- *R (operative residue).* The residue is a formal-geometric language that remains the standard medium of the theory — an operative residue of exactly the kind that the temporal anchor and the supply-level downgrade leave in place. **Pass.**

Objection (one case, dispensable). The channel rests on a single flagship case, and the scholarship it cites cuts against its necessity: the non-Euclidean style was one presentation among available alternatives, adopted for reasons that include notation and pedagogy. A category named for one dispensable episode has not earned a place in a four-way typology; what the channel calls supply, the objection calls convenience, and convenience is not a channel.

Reply. Both halves of the objection are granted, and neither touches the claim as worded. That the case count is one is priced in advance: F-C1 makes pairwise separability the typology's own falsifiability condition, so the objection, read as a prediction about further formal cases, names exactly the condition the paper has recorded as falsifiable — if a second formal case cannot be found that separates under the checks, the typology weakens, and the paper's books are open on that line. That the style was dispensable attacks a necessity claim the channel never makes: "language prior to reference" is a supply-level claim, and the downgrade is the D check doing its work, not the channel failing it. What the objection leaves untouched is the residue — the language became and remained the standard medium of the theory — and that, not necessity, is what the channel claims.

The asymmetry in the scores is informative rather than embarrassing. Walter's non-uniqueness evidence [R01] sets the internal tier: the language supply is strongly documented, the necessity of the style is not claimed, and "language prior to reference" is exactly the claim that tier supports.

3 Channel II: Controlled Fiction

Channel II takes the opposite end of the form spectrum from Channel I. A scenario is not a language waiting for a theory: it is bounded, internally run, and epistemically contested — the one form of fiction whose working is debated by philosophy in the open, case by case. That openness is why the channel matters here: where the mechanism of a fiction's work is itself a live question, the checks cannot assume an answer, and the paper's refusal to adjudicate the dispute is a constraint the channel imposes rather than a choice the paper made.

3.1 The thought-experiment dispute

Thought experiments are the canonical case of fiction doing scientific work, and the philosophical literature contains a live dispute over how the work is done. On the realist side, Brown [R04] holds that in the stock cases, thought experiments yield new knowledge of laws of nature not reducible to derivation: the scenario, once constructed, shows something that running

through premises does not by itself deliver. On the eliminativist side, Norton [R05] holds that a thought experiment is an argument in picturesque clothing: its epistemic work is fully done by a reconstructible argument from premises to conclusion, and the imagery is a vehicle, not an independent source of warrant. The dispute is live, the positions are incompatible as accounts of mechanism, and this paper does not adjudicate them; for the current state of the wider literature, see the recent survey [R45]. The case is canonical for this paper for a structural reason: the fictional status of the input is not in dispute — the scenario describes an experiment that was not run — so the dispute isolates exactly the question the channel faces, what does the fiction contribute and how would we know, with none of the fog that surrounds weaker senses of "fiction." The stock cases also have an upstream lineage of their own — the deceiving demon of the *Meditationes* [R64], the brain in a vat [R65], the simulation argument [R66] — older fictions that supplied the scenarios the modern debate refines rather than replaces; the lineage is registered here as depth of field, not as scored cases, and it earns the channel nothing.

What matters for the channel is a point the two sides share: whatever the yield, both parties hold it can be exhibited in a checkable form — Brown by isolating the insight, Norton by reconstructing the argument. The disagreement is over where the epistemic weight sits. Translatability is therefore the common ground of the dispute, and exactly the property the channel criterion needs: the channel runs on either side's terms, because either side can produce the checkable artifact.

3.2 Model-based reasoning and fictionalism

Nersessian [R06] places the thought experiment inside a wider class of model-based reasoning — concepts created through iterative construction of imagistic, analogical, and extreme-case models — and Suárez's collection [R07] supplies the fictionalist frame: fictions can represent without describing anything real, and their success does not presuppose a corresponding real property. Both lines move the question from "is the fiction true?" to "what work does the fiction do, and how is the work checked?" — the question our criteria operationalize; and they widen the channel's supply: idealized scenarios carry representational load in concept formation [R06] and modeling [R07] generally. For the assessment below, Norton's reconstruction program is the dispensability check in its strongest form, and the fictionalist frame explains how a fiction can be a working input while remaining a fiction.

3.3 The operational definition of "controlled"

We call a fictional construction **controlled** when its epistemic yield is translatable into a checkable argument or model. The channel's criterion takes the broader layer, content-translatability — the yield, once laid out, can be checked by a competent third party; warrant-translatability (re-derivable from the reconstruction alone) is the stricter form, imposed by §8's adjudication agenda on AI-generated hypotheses, which is one reason the two ends of the loop share criteria.

Two boundary clarifications: translatability is a property of the yield, not the imagery — the criterion does not require the dressing to be disposable, and so takes no sides in §3.1's dispute; and it is a threshold, not a quality grade — a yield that cannot be laid out as argument or model is outside the channel's scope, however inspiring. Translatability is thus the boundary between controlled fiction and free imagination, the channel's criterion rather than a courtesy: Norton's reconstructions are precisely translations, and Brown's stock cases are scenarios whose yields survive translation.

3.4 A physics companion case: the sorting demon

The philosophical stock cases above argue over what a thought experiment is; this case is here to show the channel's yield being cashed inside physics. Maxwell's sorting fiction — a finite

being that separates fast molecules from slow, first framed in his 1867 correspondence with Tait and published in *Theory of Heat* (1871) [R61], named a "demon" in Thomson's essay of 1874 [R61] — is a controlled fiction in exactly this channel's sense: a described, never-run experiment whose yield was claimed to follow from the description. The yield was cashed as physics, in stages. Szilard's one-molecule engine (1929) [R62] is the reconstruction that cashed it: the demon's sorting was shown to purchase its entropy decrease at an informational price. The price was made principle-grade by Landauer (1961) [R10] — the erasure of a bit costs $kT \cdot \ln 2$, the information–entropy bound this paper's Channel III already carries as residue — and the bound's experimental line and the whole demon literature are carried critically by the review and exorcist studies in the pool [R43], [R63]. The chain matters to this channel for its shape: the fiction is the generator, the physics is the constraint, and what survives is an operative relation — a bound with a price — rather than a story. Its checks, run where the chain stands: T holds — 1871, 1874, 1929, 1961, every arrow publication-dated, the head of the chain a fictional construction; D is indeterminate — whether thermodynamics would have reached the bound without the demon fiction is decided by nothing in the pool, and we do not assert it; R holds — the residue is principle-grade, the strongest form this paper scores ([R10]). The row is scored with the channel's in §9.1.

Channel claim. Controlled fiction is a routine production material of science, and the channel criterion is translatability.

Channel assessment.

- *T (temporal priority).* The scenario is constructed before the argument it organizes: construction is the fictional step, reconstruction the checkable one, and in the stock cases of the literature the construction is datable and the reconstruction follows it [R04], [R05]. **Pass.**
- *D (dispensability).* This is the disputed check by construction: Norton's position is that the fiction is dispensable, Brown's that it is not. The channel claim does not need the dispute settled. What it claims is production value under content-translation, not indispensability of the imagery; and if Norton is right — warrant-translatability being the stricter form the content layer can take — the channel's residue is the translated argument itself, which still passes R. **Unresolved by design; the claim is worded to be invariant under either resolution.**
- *R (operative residue).* The residue is a reusable argumentative and modeling technology — limiting cases, idealizations, reconstruction templates — that remains in routine scientific use after any particular scenario has served. **Pass.**

Objection (the collapse objection). If the deflationary reading of thought experiments is right — every thought experiment an argument in disguise, the imagery doing no work — then this channel's subject is empty: nothing fictional ever enters, "controlled fiction" is a flattering name for argumentation, and the channel's invariance under the dispute is not a virtue but a confession that its question was never about fiction.

Reply. The conditional is granted; the conclusion is not. Under the argument-only resolution the channel's residue is the translated argument itself — which still passes R — and the translation is the finding, not the loss: what the live dispute decides is where the fiction's work is done, and the criterion was chosen, precisely, so that the channel's claim survives either answer. The channel does not claim that imagery produces knowledge; it claims that the scenario is routine production material under a criterion both disputants grant. What the objection establishes is that one reading of the channel is thinner than the other, and the channel's wording already reflects it: the claim is stated at the tier the thinner reading still supports.

The channel passes T and R, with D unresolved by design. The invariance of the claim under the Brown–Norton outcome is a feature of the criterion, not a dodge: translatability was chosen because both disputants grant it.

4 Channel III: An Abstract Quantity Becomes an Engineering Quantity

Between the purity of Channel I and the openness of Channel II, the quantitative channel contributes the form that changes the terms of the question: a fiction that is a number. An ensemble with no material location is not a language and not a scenario; once a quantity is defined over it, the fiction acquires the properties numbers have — it can be computed, priced, and compared — and the channel's history can be written in those terms, with a formula where the other channels have a text or a thought. The gain is precision; the cost is the one downgrade in the typology, recorded where it falls in §4.

4.1 Entropy's two journeys

Channel III (the quantitative channel) runs on quantities, and its input is an abstraction rather than a fiction in the story sense. A quantity defined over an abstract, deliberately idealized object — an ensemble of messages with no material location — can travel into engineering by formal analogy and travel back into physics carrying a measurable price. The channel is classified accordingly as abstract-quantity/formal-analogy rather than fiction proper, and one fact settles the classification: statistical mechanics had given entropy a statistical reading over microstates long before the quantity was defined over message ensembles, so the physical quantity is the elder of the two and the channel cannot claim that the abstract preceded the physical. What the channel claims, and what its dated arrows carry, is the journey of the defined quantity itself — from definition over an abstract object, into engineering, and back into physics at a price.

The stock example is entropy's second life. Statistical mechanics had given entropy a statistical reading over microstates from its nineteenth-century foundations — roughly seventy years before the information-theoretic definition, a precedence the T score below is graded against rather than around. Shannon [R09] then defined the information produced by a message source as $H = -\Sigma\ p \cdot \log\ p$ — a quantity whose referent is an ensemble of messages, an object with no mass, no location, and no temperature. The definitional act is the abstracting step, and it is datable. Jaynes [R08] built the bridge back toward physics: recasting statistical mechanics as inference, he showed that the same maximization principle that governs the informational quantity governs the derivation of physical distributions — the identity of form between the two quantities was made to carry weight rather than to decorate. Landauer [R10] completed the circuit by rematerializing the quantity: the erasure of information, he showed, carries a thermodynamic cost of $kT \cdot \ln 2$ per bit, so the abstract measure re-entered physics as an expense with experimental consequences in principle — a price that a physical apparatus pays for a bookkeeping operation on an abstract object.

Each arrow in this circuit is anchored to a datable primary source: the definitional act to Shannon [R09], the bridge to Jaynes [R08], the rematerialization to Landauer [R10]; no arrow rests on recollection, and the circuit is made of definitions, derivations, and a cost, all checkable in the primary texts. Each arrow also stands without the others — which is why the verdict below is a conjunction of separately anchored facts.

4.2 Verdict and channel claim

The channel's verdict rests on three observable facts. The isomorphism of formula: the same functional form — $H = -\Sigma\ p \cdot \log\ p$ — up to a positive multiplicative constant (Boltzmann's k, with its physical units) and the choice of logarithm base, governs the abstract ensemble and the physical distribution — not a similar expression, the same one up to exactly those factors. The rematerialization: the quantity acquires an experimental price in principle, $kT \cdot \ln 2$ per erased bit [R10], now traced across survey and dynamical treatments of information thermodynamics

[R43], [R44]. And the standing of information in physical reasoning today: a quantity with thermodynamic consequences rather than a metaphor.

Channel claim. An abstract quantity, defined over an idealized object by a datable act, can enter engineering by formal analogy and flow back into physics at a measurable cost; every arrow in the circuit has an anchor, and the channel claims no priority of the abstract over the physical.

Channel assessment.

- *T (temporal priority), scored against the real chronology.* Each arrow is dated by its primary publication [R08], [R09], [R10] — at the arrow level, the best-dated material in this paper. The channel-level demand — the input preceding the scientific use credited to it — does not survive the chronology: statistical mechanics had given entropy a statistical reading over microstates roughly seventy years before Shannon's definitional act, so a kindred physical quantity predates the abstraction. **Scoped pass: arrow-level dating holds; the channel-level priority claim is downgraded, and the channel is labeled abstract-quantity/formal-analogy accordingly.**
- *D (dispensability).* Whether communication theory would be equally parsimonious without H is decided by nothing in the pool, and we do not assert it. The channel claim rests on the anchorability of the arrows, not the indispensability of the quantity — the same supply-level discipline as Channel I. **Indeterminate; graded accordingly.**
- *R (operative residue).* The residue is an operative quantity with units, prices, and experimental consequences in principle. **Pass.**

Objection (the priority objection). Statistical mechanics gave entropy a statistical reading over microstates some seventy years before the definitional act this channel credits: the physical quantity is prior, the abstract definition late, and by the channel's own temporal standard the story runs backwards — the "feedback" is an artifact of telling it from the abstract end.

Reply. The priority the objection establishes is real, and the channel has already paid it: the channel-level demand does not survive the chronology, the assessment downgrades channel-level T, and the claim sentence itself disclaims priority of the abstract over the physical. What the objection does not touch is the arrow-level record — the dated isomorphism, the dated entry into engineering, the dated rematerialization at a measured price per erased bit. The objection re-prices the channel; it does not close it: the arrows the channel claims are the arrows that survive.

The channel holds T at the arrow level with the channel-level priority downgraded; D is indeterminate; the claim is stated at the anchored-arrow level. The difference from Channel I's "partial pass" is evidential, not rhetorical: there the pool carries positive evidence of non-uniqueness [R01] and the check runs, downgrading the claim to the supply level; here the pool contains no study of alternative formulations, so the check cannot run, and the claim is graded to be invariant under its outcome. This is the most mechanical of the four channels, deliberately so: quantities carry their definitions with them, so the feedback is exhibited as a sameness of functional form plus a cost — though not, as the T score records, without conceding that the physical quantity came first.

5 Channel IV: Narrative Fiction into the AI Agenda

The narrative channel is the form most readily dismissed as mere influence, and its inclusion is methodological rather than sentimental: narrative is the one form of fiction whose entry into science leaves a datable trail of reception — inquiries, letters, published answers — rather than a diffusion of mood. The difficulty here is not dating the trail but crediting it, and the

channel is included precisely so that the three checks, rather than reputation, decide how much an agenda-setting story can be credited with.

5.1 A direct agenda-setting case

The cleanest case in this channel is also the most literal. Sagan's novel Contact [R40] turns on rapid interstellar travel; the novelist's inquiry to a physicist — whether such travel could be made scientifically respectable — is the documented hinge of the case [R41], and the answer became the published analysis of traversable wormholes by Morris and Thorne [R11]. The passability question was answered as physics: what holds a wormhole open, and what conditions a traveler must meet, are derived in the journal record, stated as equations rather than as plot.

The evidence structure is what makes the case flagship-grade for this channel. The chain from the novelist's question to the published solution is anchored by the authors' own accounts of the episode (**self-statement anchor**); the scientific content is anchored by the peer-reviewed paper itself (**primary-source anchor**). Narrative-channel evidence usually has one anchor or the other — a story that influenced someone, or a paper whose fictional origin is hearsay; here both ends of the same chain are anchored, and the two anchor types meet at a datable event. The case also displays the channel's characteristic evidence problem, and its solution: influence usually leaves recollections and little else, so the channel's standard is that a recollection must meet a published artifact — recollection supplies the fictional end, the artifact the scientific end. The case is one case: its strength is evidentiary, and it does not by itself establish a pattern.

5.2 Ontological vocabulary

Narrative fiction also supplies the nouns an agenda needs, and vocabulary supply is the channel's most mechanical evidence form, because dictionary records are checkable artifacts. The word robot entered the language through Karel Čapek's play R.U.R. (1920) — the word itself was suggested to Čapek by his brother Josef Čapek, as Čapek himself acknowledged; the Oxford English Dictionary's earliest recorded attestation of robotics falls in Asimov's 1941 story "Liar!" [R12]. These are **lexical anchors**: the record is public, dated, and independent of recollection. The vocabulary is not decorative: robot and robotics are the term of art for an entire artifact class across law, industry, and research, and the term descends, by dictionary record, from the fiction that named it.

The same holds for singularity. Vinge's 1993 essay [R13], published in an interdisciplinary NASA-sponsored volume, states the coming of intelligence beyond the human threshold as a near-term engineering question; the singularity vocabulary in its AI-agenda sense carries this named, datable textual anchor (**named textual anchor**). We make no claim about the word's earlier history; what the channel needs is that the agenda-bearing sense has an anchor, and it does.

A third anchor form enters with the oldest chain this channel carries: fiction to concept, link by link, each link a dated primary text. Hoffmann's *Der Sandmann* (1816) [R58] builds its unease on the automaton Olympia — a machine-woman whose near-human imperfection is the story's engine. Freud's essay on the uncanny (1919) [R59] takes that same figure, the lifelike doll, as a core instance of the uncanny — the familiar returned as strange — a documented engagement: the analysis runs on the fiction's own case. Fifty-one years later, the roboticist Mori named the design-side of the same structure *bukimi no tani* (1970) [R60] — human affinity collapsing as resemblance rises — and the concept's English circulation is anchored by the authorized translation (2012) [R60], whose English name — *uncanny* valley — carries the psychological lineage into the term itself. The chain's evidence form differs from the channel's other cases, and the difference is declared: the 1919 link is a documented engagement, but the 1970 link is an independent arrival at the same structure; no participant recalls supplying anything to anyone — the continuity is the printed record and the phenomenon's identity, not a documented

request — and the case is honestly one grade below Contact's self-statement hinge. What the fiction supplied is exact and datable: the phenomenon's structure, near-human mismatch as an object of thought, first articulated in a narrative fiction, named independently in psychology and in engineering, now an operative term of art. The chain's checks, run where it stands: T holds — 1816, 1919, 1970, 2012, each dated to a primary text, the head of the chain a narrative fiction; D is indeterminate — whether the terms would have arisen without the fiction's articulation is decided by nothing in the pool, and we do not assert it; R holds — *uncanny valley* is an operative term of art in human–robot interaction and the design of humanlike characters, five decades in circulation. The row is scored with the channel's in §9.1.

A lexical or named textual anchor does double duty in the assessment below: it dates the vocabulary (T), and it exhibits the residue (R), since a term of art still in circulation is an operative residue by definition. Both anchors land in this paper's territory: the robotics vocabulary names and regulates a class of autonomous artifacts, and the singularity vocabulary organizes the discourse about AI trajectories.

5.3 The quantitative tier

Beyond flagship cases and vocabulary, the channel has a quantitative tier: recent studies examine the association between science-fiction narratives and technology topics quantitatively [R14], [R15] (**quantitative-study tier**). The tier moves the channel from anecdote to measurement — the hypothesis that science fiction supplies topics to technology is testable at study level. We do not assert the strength or the direction of the association; the tier's contribution is its existence and form, and it disciplines the rest of the channel: the flagship case and the vocabulary are not asked to carry statistical weight, and the studies are not asked to explain single episodes.

5.4 Evidence tiers and the forward pointer

The channel's evidence comes in three grades, each with an anchor. Self-statement anchors: the participants document the fictional origin themselves ([R11]). Lexical and named textual anchors: dictionary records and dated primary texts fix the vocabulary ([R12], [R13]). Quantitative studies: the association is measured rather than recounted ([R14], [R15]). The grades are stated separately, and none is asked to carry more than it supports: the flagship case is one case; the vocabulary is supply, not necessity; the quantitative tier measures association, not mechanism. This grading is what allows the channel claim below to be exact about what narrative fiction does — it supplies nouns and it sets agendas — without borrowing strength from the grade above.

Channel claim. Narrative fiction both supplies vocabulary and sets agendas; the evidence is graded by anchor type, and every grade has an anchor.

Channel assessment.

- *T (temporal priority).* Precedences are datable, and each precedence carries its anchor type with it: the novel's question precedes the wormhole paper (self-statement anchor, [R11]); 1920 and 1941 precede the modern robotics vocabulary (lexical anchor, [R12]); 1993 precedes the discourse the singularity essay anchors (named textual anchor, [R13]). **Pass.**
- *D (dispensability).* Whether the same vocabulary and agenda would have arisen without the fictional sources is decided by nothing in the pool, and we do not assert it. Vocabulary supply is the kind of input that has substitutes; the channel claim does not need indispensability. **Indeterminate; graded accordingly.**
- *R (operative residue).* The residue is operative: a term of art in law, industry, and research; a discourse-organizing concept with a datable anchor; and a class of spacetime solutions entered into the physics literature with published conditions [R11]. **Pass.**

Objection (the substitutes objection). Vocabulary is the most substitutable of inputs: coin another word, borrow another story. The precedences are dated, but dating a precedence is not crediting a contribution — the same terms would have been coined, the same agendas set, and "supply" is a name for what would have happened anyway.

Reply. The objection is a counterfactual, and by this paper's discipline a counterfactual is decided by evidence or held open. No study in the pool decides it, so D is recorded as indeterminate — the channel does not claim the vocabulary was needed, only that it was supplied and left a residue, and each precedence carries its anchor type. What would refute the channel is not the objection as stated but its evidential form: a study showing full substitutability with no residue lost, which would downgrade the channel through F-C2's route — a route the paper has left open on purpose.

Channel IV is also where the loop stops being purely historical: an engineering-grade instance of the full pipeline — fictional world-building to formal specification to pre-registered adjudication to falsifiable experiment, with negative results disclosed in full — is on record and examined in §7 on the same footing as the cases of this paper; the checks transfer unchanged, and what changes is the tier on which the verdict products are graded (§1.2).

6 Method: Porting the Hard Criteria into AI Claim Adjudication

This section states a method, and the method has a conceptual shape worth stating before its tables. The three checks of §1.2 are one discipline in three tenses — a dated crossing, a settled residue, and no necessity claimed — and this section asks what that discipline becomes when the timing of judgment is reversed: not fiction entering science under a verdict the record renders after the fact, but claims about machine intelligence made to stand before a verdict fixed in advance of the run. The mapping below is that reversal made concrete: its rows pair the genre's self-policing vocabulary with the falsifiability vocabulary of AI claim adjudication, and the pairing is a structural claim, not a resemblance — each row shares a failure mode across its two ends, and the sharing is checkable row by row. A criterion travels exactly when the failure it catches travels; that is the sense in which the criteria below are portable, and the sense a reader is invited to check. One row is an import rather than a construction, and it is declared where it occurs; the mapping's candor about its own sources is part of the method it carries.

6.1 The criteria, taken from the genre's own definitions

Hard science fiction polices itself, and the policing has named criteria. The genre's reference entry quotes Allen Steele's working definition — "Hard sf is the form of imaginative literature that uses either established or carefully extrapolated science as its backbone" (Steele, "Hard Again", quote as cited in [R37]) — and states two guardrails in its own voice: "Hard sf should not, however, wilfully ignore or break known scientific principles", and hard sf "should seek to provide natural rather than supernatural or transcendental explanations for the events and phenomena it describes" [R37]. The same entry concedes that a rigorous definition of the category may be impossible [R37]. The anthologies that frame the modern hard-SF canon [R36] exemplify the tradition these statements describe; their capture limit is recorded in the Appendix. From this record, and strictly within it, this paper distills four working demands for "hard": internal consistency, no supernatural checks, continuity with known science, and checkability of the world's claims by observers inside the world. These demands are adopted as the definition domain, inherited by the mapping in rows M1, M2, M3, and M5. Row M4 is declared rather than smuggled in. The genre's distilled record contains no freeze-before-the-run demand, so M4's criterion is imported from the pre-registration and third-party-recomputation literature ([R47]–[R50]) rather than mapped from the genre. The diegetic-prototype record

([R32], [R33]) is carried in that row as motivation, not as the criterion's source. The reason for taking the genre's own standard rather than a philosophical ideal of rigor is strategic: the genre standard is operational — reviewers, readers, and writers apply it to manuscripts — and operational standards port; ideals of rigor do not.

Two preliminary reductions keep the mapping honest: the genre's criteria are criteria for a world, not a paper, so each must be re-expressed as a criterion for a claim; and the genre enforces through review practice, not adjudication protocols, so the mapping must supply the enforcement mechanism the genre never needed. Both appear as the mapping invariant below.

6.2 The mapping table

The mapping's invariant is a single question, identical on both ends of every row: given the ledger, can a third party recompute the conclusion from the ledger alone? On the hard-SF side the ledger is the world's stated physics; on the AI side it is the claim's stated support. Each row below pairs a genre criterion with its AI-research counterpart and names the failure mode the row exists to catch.

No.	Hard-SF criterion (pool source)	AI-claim criterion (provenance stated per row)	Shared failure mode
M1	Internal consistency: the world's books run no deficit — this paper's formalization, prompted by the guardrails recorded in [R37]	Claim and evidence structure agree; the support covers what is asserted — this paper's formalization (claim–support correspondence: [R46]), prompted by the failure modes documented in [R38]	Self-contradiction
M2	No supernatural checks are written — grounded in the entry's standard: "natural rather than supernatural or transcendental explanations for the events and phenomena it describes" (quote as cited in [R37])	No appeals to undelivered future capability [R39]	Deus ex machina
M3	Continuity with known science — grounded in the entry's guardrail: "Hard sf should not, however, wilfully ignore or break known scientific principles" (quote as cited in [R37])	Anchoring in existing reviewable artifacts — this paper's formalization, prompted by the failure modes documented in [R38]	Bare assertion
M4	No counterpart among the genre's four distilled demands: the record demands no freeze-before-the-run adjudication of a world, so this row's criterion is imported, not mapped — declared in §6.1. Motivation, not source: narrative artifacts can carry engineering commitments; the diegetic prototype has documented instances [R32], [R33]	Adjudication procedure pre-registered, recomputable by a third party — this paper's formalization (pre-registration: [R47], [R48]; third-party recomputation: [R49], [R50]), an import per the left cell, prompted by the failure modes documented in [R38], [R39]	Changing the rules after the fact
M5	The world's claims are checkable by observers inside the world — this paper's distillation, grounded in the definition the entry quotes: "established or carefully extrapolated science as its backbone" (Steele, quote as cited in [R37])	Falsifiable, with the kill line defined before the experiment runs — this paper's formalization (falsifiability: [R51], [R52]), prompted by the failure modes documented in [R38], [R39]	Unfalsifiable rhetoric

The table claims a constructed structural parallel — row-wise pairing of criteria with shared

failure modes — and nothing stronger; "isomorphism" is reserved for the formula-level identity of Channel III, and no row-to-row isomorphism is claimed here. One row is an import, declared as such (M4; §6.1). It is not an equivalence theorem: the two sides differ in enforcement, and the differences are inherited by the pipeline. What makes each row a mapping rather than an analogy is the shared failure mode: a genre manuscript and an AI paper can fail the same row in the same way, and a third party can check for the failure in both.

Anonymous interface. The practice that the M4 row formalizes — freeze the adjudication before the run, and hold the record to a recomputability standard — is systematized in an archived companion study of auditability and falsifiability in LLM-reasoning research, cited here as the anonymized pool entry [R56]: withheld in this edition, to be restored in a later revised edition, available to any reader from the author on request, and attested by the authors of this paper rather than independently verified (§1.3(ii)). The row itself is this paper's formalization, and its criteria stand on the open literature ([R47]–[R50]) with or without that entry.

Two sources carry the failure-mode side of the table: Wagstaff's method criticism, which argues that machine learning research should be judged by delivered, real-world capability rather than by benchmark claims alone [R38], and Lipton and Steinhardt's catalogue of troubling trends in which rhetoric outruns evidence [R39]. Of the AI-side criteria, only M2's no-future-capability demand restates a concern one of these sources states directly. The criteria of M1, M3, M4, and M5 are this paper's formalization, prompted by the failure modes those sources document, with their methodological originals cited in place ([R46]–[R52]; row-by-row provenance consolidated in the Appendix). The originals supply the practices the criteria formalize; the formalization, and the mapping, remain this paper's. The failure modes are those two sources'; the criteria that catch them are this paper's.

6.3 What exists, and where it stops

The practice of using narrative artifacts to steer real research and development is documented, not hypothetical, and the pool carries six entries across three literatures. Science fiction prototyping proposes fictional scenarios as a source of technology ideas for engineering audiences [R30]. Design fiction states the program in its general form [R31] and operates it as an empirical HCI method [R35]. Sociological studies of the film industry document cinematic depictions feeding back into laboratory practice [R32], [R33]. An analysis of computing's future discourse shows research agendas organized by the imaginaries they inherit [R34]. Together these establish the forward channel's practical existence at the level of agendas and prototypes.

What this line does not have is an adjudication tier: its methods are generative and ethnographic — they produce ideas and document influence, but they do not freeze a verdict function in advance, and they do not kill. The stop is not a failure of the literature; it is where its questions end. On the other side, the ML method-criticism literature names the failure modes — unsupported claims, post-hoc rules, rhetoric outrunning evidence [R38], [R39] — but no pipeline that ports a genre's own discipline into claim adjudication. The two literatures face each other across exactly the gap the mapping table formalizes.

To the extent of the three-line search recorded in §1.3(iv), the mapping has not been stated as a structural parallel with a portable pipeline.

6.4 The four-stage pipeline

The pipeline has four stages, each with an input, a product, a criterion from the table, and a named failure mode.

- **S (Setting).** Input: narrative fiction. Product: a self-consistent world setting with its own ontological vocabulary. Criterion: M1. Failure mode: a hidden contradiction in the world's books.

- **F (Formalization).** Input: the setting. Product: a formal system — identities, state spaces, metrics — into which the setting's vocabulary is transcribed. Criteria: M2, M3. Failure mode: metaphor with no formal counterpart.
- **P (Pre-registration).** Input: the formal system. Product: a frozen adjudication function with an external anchor, fixed before any run. Criterion: M4. Failure mode: changing the rules after seeing the data.
- **E (Experiment).** Input: the frozen adjudication function. Product: a verdict — including a kill. Criterion: M5. Failure mode: unfalsifiable rhetoric.

The pipeline's discipline is concentrated in one requirement: the kill line must be defined before the experiment runs, and the verdict function must be executable by a third party who did not build the system. A pipeline that can merely confirm is a pipeline with M5 removed, and M5 is the row that makes the rest of the mapping more than rhetoric. One calibration belongs with the requirement rather than in a footnote: executability is a property of the record, not a report of who has executed. The instance of §7 was built and run by its own authors; in this revised edition, third-party executability runs through the public repository and its full digests (§7.1), and a third party has in fact recomputed the anchors and headline numbers (§7.2). The requirement is met in substance on that public record; the machine-readable handoff carrier and the first audit record were deposited in the public repository on 2026-09-29 and 2026-09-30 (commits `9b6d80a` and `3eee223`, SHA-256 prefixes `9fccd007be9f` and `ed5eb708f332`; Appendix).

Method claim. The hard-SF criteria and the falsifiability criteria of AI research claims are structurally parallel under the mapping M1–M5 — row-wise pairing of criteria with shared failure modes, one row (M4) importing its criterion from the pre-registration literature and declared as such — and the four-stage pipeline ports the mapping into a worked method, demonstrated on one artifact on the given benchmarks at the stated statistical power (§7.3), not as a general working methodology. The claim weakens if any row's two ends fail to share form and failure mode under inspection, or if the pipeline cannot be executed end to end on a concrete artifact. Section 7 reports such an execution.

7 Case Study: An Engineering Instance

This section examines one documented artifact — a public engineering project, the Deposon project, whose identity was anonymized in the previous edition and is restored in this revised edition — on the same footing as the cases of §2–§5. The restoration covers the project's name, the fictitious entity's name (the Deposon, the scattering entity named within its fiction), the project-name tokens inside artifact basenames, the path prefixes, and the public pointer: the repository `https://github.com/zeroandcat/Deposon` at the citation-frozen commit, under the availability terms stated in the Appendix. The token "GT" that remains inside some artifact basenames below is the field-generic abbreviation of "ground truth," not a project-name token; the basenames are part of what the frozen digests cover and cannot be altered without breaking the anchors they attest. The restoration touches no anchor digest, no number, and no field-path semantics: the five anchor prefixes, every measured value, and every field path in this section are byte-identical to the frozen record, now printed at their repository-relative paths with the previous edition's `anon` substitution retired. The tier discipline of §1.2 applies in full: what follows is the pre-registered adjudication tier, not the historical tier, and every number is cited by its field path into the frozen record.

7.1 The chain, replayed end to end

S. A science-fiction worldbuilding exercise posits a fictitious scattering entity, the Deposon, whose physics is a three-channel energy law: an incident path's energy splits into transmission,

reflection, and irreversible dissipation. The setting supplies a conservation bookkeeping identity and a vocabulary for reasoning about exchange.

F. The formalization binds each node of an LLM-generated concept-decomposition graph to a two-parameter state of that entity, so that traversing reasoning paths undergo three-channel scattering obeying the constructive identity T+R+A=1 for arbitrary parameters; the reverse dynamics are additionally formalized as a game on the graph, with an audited scalar carrying monotonicity and near-gradient readings, and the empirical coordination ratio (ECR) as the distribution-level metric.

P. The adjudication layer is frozen before runs as pure verdict functions with SHA-256 anchors, printed here as twelve-character prefixes and consolidated in Table 1 (handoff record, field `preregistration_anchors_sha256_12`; the record's public carriers, including the machine-readable carrier deposited at commit `9b6d80a`, are declared in §7.1). Every key number below maps to a frozen field; hand-copying is forbidden by the artifact's own protocol.

Frozen artifact (repository path)	**SHA-256 prefix**	**Bytes**
`docs/GT_FORMALIZATION_v1.md`	aeefb8ef6972	19,100
`run_v21_gtformal.py`	9bbe43f41fa8	16,600
`run_v22_p1c.py`	6e9673205dc0	7,236
`docs/SPEC_GT2B.md`	68a5b08ef007	3,318
`docs/SPEC_GT8C.md`	6b09de9911c0	6,326

Table 1: The five frozen pre-registration anchors, cited at their repository-relative paths in the public repository at the citation-frozen commit (§7.1, Appendix); prefixes are twelve-character SHA-256 values, byte-identical to the frozen record.

E. Three results, in ascending order of severity.

The conservation identity survives audit. The maximum per-path deviation across all variants and benchmarks is $2.220446049250313\times10^{-16}$ — the scale of double-precision machine epsilon, against an implementation tolerance of 10^{-6} — closed (pre-registered). The quantified coordination reading lands at median ECR $= 4/3$ over the 17 finite-valued graphs, with coverage of 20 of 22 graphs; three graphs read Infinity, two graphs lack arm data, both disclosed as-is.

The dynamical tier dies. The kill protocol is systematic in its graph sampling (61 graphs in five families) and complete at the state level: all 6,760 states of the 338-task corpus, 20 steps each. All three formalized dynamical-equivalence propositions are falsified. P1a: maximum deviation 0.8569, an O(1) gap that does not vanish with step size. T-P1b: minimum directional cosine -1.0. T-P1c: killed on both lines — an 81-point grid over $\tau\in[0,4]$ reaches minimum cosine -1.0 at the best global τ, the per-state optimal $\tau*$ again reaches -1.0, and the per-state $\tau*$ median is 0. The potential-game reading is downgraded accordingly, to approximate (cyclic-graph median residual 0.669).

Field paths for every number above are consolidated in Table 2; the availability terms of the public repository and the full SHA-256 digests are stated in the Appendix. The handoff record's machine-readable carrier has been part of the public repository since 2026-09-29 (commit `9b6d80a`, repository root); its fields are carried, values identical, by the archived source markdown and were re-verified item by item by the third-party recompute record (§7.2). A reader working from the public text and the public repository can now execute the recomputation that M4 asks of a third party — hashing the five anchors of Table 1 against the repository's files and tracing every field path of Tables 2 and 3 into the repository's artifacts. Making the record and its checks available during evaluation is the standard the machine-learning reproducibility program set for its own venues [R49]. That demand is now met in substance: an independent party recomputed the anchors and the headline numbers on 2026-09-18 (§7.2), and the record is public at the citation-frozen commit (Appendix).

Result	Frozen field path
Conservation deviation ($2.220446049250313 \times 10^{-16}$)	`results/deposon_benchmark_v1_4_gsm8k.json` · `physics_audit.t_plus_r_plus_a_max_deviation`
Median ECR and coverage (4/3; 20/22)	handoff record (§7.1), field `headline_results.GT4_ECR`
Kill scope (61 graphs; 6,760 states)	handoff record (§7.1), field `headline_results.enumeration_scope`
P1a / T-P1b / T-P1c	handoff record (§7.1), field `headline_results.P1a_P1b_T_P1c`; source `results/deposon_v22_p1c.json` · `verdict.min_cos_at_best_global_tau` and `verdict.min_cos_per_state_best_tau`; measured fields in `results/deposon_v21_gtformal.json` · `verdict.P1a_deviation.max_dev_inf` and `verdict.T_P1b.min_cosine`
Potential-game downgrade (0.669)	handoff record (§7.1), field `headline_results.P2`

Table 2: Field-path index for the E-stage results; every path is byte-identical to the frozen record at the repository's citation-frozen commit, and the handoff-record fields are carried by the public carriers declared in §7.1.

7.2 The first action: verdicts before the runs

The three falsifications are the pipeline working as designed, not a failure of it: the verdict is the pipeline's first action, its floor rather than its point. M5 requires that the kill line be defined before the run; the run then killed. What survives at the dynamical level is no more than consistency-tier evidence, and the artifact's own verdict language records the downgrade. Because verdict functions are frozen before their runs, the conservation pass and the dynamical kills stand at the same freeze level, and the pass cannot be read as the product of a lenient protocol. At the audit level, an independent rerun (2026-08-30) passed with bit-identical recomputation, the five anchors above, and nine provenance spot checks (handoff record, field `headline_results.audit`) — the books were not merely kept but re-kept by a second pair of hands. That rerun's own log was deposited in the public repository on 2026-09-30 (commit `3eee223`, `_september_workspace/results/AUDIT_2026-08-30.json`, since relocated under the repository's mirror prefix with bytes unchanged); its occurrence and outcome are carried by the handoff record's audit field and cited as its prior by the second recompute's record below. A third party further recomputed the record on 2026-09-18: the five anchors matched bit-identically (5/5), and the headline numbers were traced item by item to the frozen fields, with the two artifacts `results/deposon_benchmark_v1_4_gsm8k.json` and `results/deposon_v20_crossval.json` checked only at the summary-field level and flagged for pull-back to full recomputation (record: `_september_workspace/results/_kimi_ftfb_s7_independent_recompute_2026_09_18.json`, SHA-256 prefix `879db0217f04`, deposited in the public repository at the citation-frozen commit). Negative results are disclosed here as assets: what cannot be falsified cannot be killed.

7.3 What this instance is, and is not

The instance's honest positioning has three parts. (i) The channel attribute: the loop closes through the audit and epistemic channel, and the capability channel shows no detectable difference at the stated power. On real benchmarks the layer is indistinguishable from a trivial six-keyword rule filter reading nothing beyond label strings — on GSM8K the filter scores 0.87 against the layer's 0.85 (McNemar p=0.5), on StrategyQA 0.899 against 0.899 (p=1.0) — and at these sample sizes the detectable-difference threshold is roughly ±10 percentage points, so

smaller increments are not excluded, disclosed as-is. Plain chain-of-thought outperforms the layer on GSM8K, 0.97 versus 0.85. Fusion with a semantic prior dilutes rather than helps: physics 0.484→0.452 and historical 0.783→0.739 at the λ=0.5 convex combination. None of these numbers is massaged out of the record; field paths are consolidated in Table 3.

Result	**Frozen field path**
Filter comparison and power honesty (0.87/0.85, p=0.5; 0.899/0.899, p=1.0; ±10pp)	handoff record (§7.1), field `headline_results.E9_5_power_honest`; artifact `results/deposon_v22_e95ci.json`
CoT baseline versus layer (0.97/0.85)	`results/deposon_benchmark_v1_4_gsm8k.json` · `cot_baseline_accuracy` and `unified_accuracy`
Fusion at λ=0.5 (0.484→0.452; 0.783→0.739)	`results/deposon_v20_crossval.json` · per-graph fields `prior_arm_eval.`<graph>`.hybrid_norm`@0.5

Table 3: Field-path index for the §7.3 results; every path is byte-identical to the frozen record at the repository's citation-frozen commit, and the handoff-record fields are carried by the public carriers declared in §7.1.

(ii) The magnitude attribute. The instance runs structurally parallel to the Channel I pattern — a fictional physics supplies a formal language, the language is adjudicated, a verdict lands — but its magnitude is not comparable to the non-Euclidean case, and nothing in this paper claims otherwise. (iii) The not-yet attribute. A non-Euclidean-grade loop would require third-party adoption of the formal language by a community that did not build it; that adoption has not occurred, and no uniqueness claim is made about the instance — the positioning is exactly "engineering-grade, mid-strength."

7.4 Scoring on the same table

Scored by the three checks of §1.2, on the same footing as §2–§5; the consolidated table is §9.1. Temporal priority: the fictional setting precedes the formal system it seeds, anchored by the frozen record. The anchor is an author-attested freeze: it buys verifiability, not independence, and its standing is stated in the Appendix. The five printed anchor prefixes date the formalization and the verdict functions to before the runs they adjudicate, on the artifact's own attestation. The freeze is now backed by an independent third-party recomputation (2026-09-18), but not yet by a trusted time-stamp or a third-party archive — the upgrade path is half executed. Dispensability: not claimed and not needed; the case rests on executability, and D is out of scope per §1.2. Operative residue: the machine-checkable ledger — identities, verdict functions, and anchors that continue to run after the fiction has done its work. The instance is therefore scored T as a provisional pass — the anchor is author-attested, of lesser independence than the historical rows — and R as a pass, on the pre-registered tier, with D out of scope; its evidential weight is one mid-strength case, asked to carry nothing more.

8 Outlook: Machine Worldviews and the Reverse Channel

Scope declaration. This section is an open-question agenda: it makes no prediction; its product is the set of conditions under which the reverse channel would become decidable — not evidence that it has opened.

8.1 The term, and the existence line

The term *machine worldview* has no settled definition. The survey literature covers the definitional debate over world models without closing it [R20], and this paper adds no definition of its own: the term enters here exactly as it entered the thesis sentence of §1.2. What this section needs is an existence line — that AI systems increasingly build and act through internal models of the domains they face — and that line is documented. Agents have been trained inside learned internal simulations of their environments since the work that opened this literature [R16]; world-model training has been scaled to master diverse domains in a single agent [R17]; generative systems have moved from producing frames to producing interactive environments [R18]; and a world-foundation-model platform has been proposed as shared infrastructure for physical AI [R19]. On the interpretability side, a sequence model trained on Othello moves — the game given as move sequences, never as rules — was found to carry an internal representation of the board [R21]: whatever "worldview" turns out to mean once the definitional debate settles [R20], an internal structure that encodes a domain the system was never told about is the phenomenon the term is reaching for. At the architectural level, a position paper makes world models the core component of a proposed program for autonomous machine intelligence [R22].

One difference point must be declared: the survey that anchors the definitional debate [R20] does not ask the question this section asks — whether such internal structures feed back into the sciences. That is a gap this section opens, not a criticism of that survey.

8.2 The pipeline line

On the production side, a line of systems now automates recognizable parts of the research pipeline itself: the AI Scientist generates research ideas, writes code, runs experiments, and writes the manuscript [R23], continued in a second version [R24]; Coscientist demonstrates autonomous planning and execution of chemistry experiments [R25]; a multi-agent co-scientist generates and ranks research proposals at scale [R26]; and Agent Laboratory wires ideation, experimentation, and write-up into a single workflow [R27]. The ideas such systems propose have also been placed under human blind review at scale, with expert reviewers judging machine-proposed and human-proposed ideas under controlled conditions [R28].

The pipeline line matters here for one reason: the S and F stages of §6.4 — setting and formalization — are now reachable by machine actors. What the line does not yet show, at the granularity of the pool's documentation, is the P stage: a frozen adjudication function with an external anchor and an executable kill line, fixed before any run. And the failure-mode audit any such stage would inherit is already written: the known failure modes of ML-based science, data leakage prominent among them, are catalogued and reproducibility-tested as corruptions of conclusions that leave a paper's own books looking clean [R29]; that catalogue is where an audit of machine-generated hypotheses would begin.

8.3 The adjudication agenda

Declaration sentence. Machine worldviews may be forming, and they may be good ones; neither observation is evidence of feedback. Whether machine worldviews feed back into the sciences is decidable: it stands or falls on whether machine-generated hypotheses can be frozen into formal specifications, adjudicated by functions pre-registered with external anchors, and killed or kept by experiments whose kill lines were defined before the runs — the same pipeline as §6.4, the same checks as §1.2, no lower standard.

The agenda has three conditions, inherited from the pipeline: the machine's output must be landable in a formal specification fixed before adjudication (freezable); the adjudication function must be pre-registered and recomputable by a third party from the record alone (anchored)

— the stricter warrant-translatability layer, imposed because the pre-registered tier can afford it; and the verdict must be executable as a decisive test (killable). F-C3 is the section's falsifiability condition: if machine-generated hypotheses, run under pre-registered adjudication, systematically leave no kill line to hang, the reverse channel is declared dead.

What would count as a positive result is stated with equal care, so that the burden does not fall silently on the negative side. A machine-generated hypothesis would count as reverse-channel feedback when (i) it is traceable to the machine's internal model — an input this paper treats as fiction-analogous rather than as a fictional input: whether a learned world model counts as a fiction in the sense of §2–§5 is a definitional question this paper does not settle, and the agenda does not lean on the answer; (ii) it precedes the human verification it receives; (iii) it survives a pre-registered kill attempt; and (iv) it leaves an operative residue — a vocabulary, a quantity, or a formal system — inside a scientific community that did not build the machine. The four elements map onto the three checks of §1.2 and onto F-C3; no one of them is sufficient alone, and none is asserted to exist today.

The audit vocabulary for such an adjudication — auditable when a third party that holds the record can recompute the claim from the record alone — is systematized in the companion study [R56] (§6.2). For the §7 instance, that availability now runs through the public repository declared in §7.1; whether any reader takes the recomputation up is outside the authors' control (§7.1, §7.2).

8.4 The loop family and its wider formulation

Scope declaration. This subsection registers lineage, not results. It names two related works — one public, one in preparation — declares what each supplies, and states what neither inherits from the checks of this paper. It makes no prediction, and it adds no claim beyond the scopes of §1.2 and §8.3.

The loop of this paper is one member of a family. A companion position statement in the same research line, the *Worldview–Geometry Loop* [R57], carries the loop proposition at worldview level: that machine assistance now makes the hard-SF method — the deliberate variation of a setting's constraint axioms, consequences followed out — tractable at industrial scale, and that such world-systems, on the precedent of the non-Euclidean case, may in time act back on the representational space of the machines that produce them. The declaration is built to be killed: the companion states three kill lines of its own, all three currently open, and stakes its standing on them. The two works share the family skeleton — the non-Euclidean precedent, the two-way-loop form, the orientation to killable propositions — carried at different strengths: in the companion, as declaration; in this paper, as apparatus, run on a worked instance (§7). The division of labor is complementary by design: the companion supplies the proposition; this paper supplies the criteria any future instance of that proposition can be scored under. Neither work's claims rest on the other's. Their instances coincide — the companion's first complete instance is the project examined as this paper's §7 case — and the coincidence is stated rather than left tacit: there it is carried as the loop's instance; here it is scored on the same footing as the historical cases, engineering-grade, mid-strength. No claim of either work rests on the coincidence.

Both issue from the same dialogue-driven research practice — author-directed, AI-assisted, as stated in the paper's AI use disclosure — and the lineage is declared on that basis: within that practice, the loop proposition was first articulated as the understanding of the AI agent that completed the line's first public work. A shared origin is not a shared verdict: neither work is evidence for the other — a precedent whose order (imagined first, formalized second, taken up by physics only last) also fixes the family's scale of standing: earned at the formalization step, not borrowed from adoption; a scale the line's further members extend, each in its own register.

That line is being extended, by declaration, toward a *mind–matter formulation*: a work

in preparation in the same research line, which would carry the loop's two-way form into the relation between mental and physical description. It is registered here at statement level only — a direction named, not a formulation claimed. It inherits no guarantee, no verdict, and no kill line from this paper; whatever standing it eventually claims will rest on pre-registrations of its own, or it will not claim standing.

The family closes along the line the term itself ascends: the existence line of §8.1 is documented; the *Worldview–Geometry Loop* is declared [R57], not evidenced here; a mind–matter formulation is named as direction, nothing more. The two-way form the family shares is a cycle rather than a symmetry: the bounds crossed are inherited — precipitated, on the precedent's record, from the answers to earlier crossings — and each crossing is answered in turn, settling into the next bounds. The crossing initiates; the answer settles; and the settlement, not the crossing, is what the record can check. What this paper adds to the family is the adjudication agenda of §8.3 — the conditions under which a member of this line, any member, could be declared to have fed back, or declared dead — offered on the same terms to the family as to anyone else: no member of the line is exempt, and none is privileged.

It is worth noticing the asymmetry with the forward channels. Sections §2–§5 reconstructed feedback after the fact, from anchors left behind by participants; the reverse channel, if it opens, would be feedback whose evidence regime is chosen in advance. The criteria of this paper were built for the historical tier; their portability to the pre-registered tier is what §6 established and §7 exhibited. The reverse channel is thus the case where this paper's two instruments meet.

9 Conclusion: The Criteria Turned on Themselves

A paper that lives by criteria should be willing to die by them. This closing section scores the paper's cases on the paper's own checks (§9.1), turns the same checks on the paper's own thesis, states the limitations (§9.2), and re-records the kill lines (§9.3).

9.1 The master table

The per-section scores of §2–§5 and §7.4 are consolidated here; nothing is re-scored. The two case-level additions of this edition (the uncanny-valley chain, §5.2; the demon chain, §3.4) enter as new rows; nothing already scored is re-scored.

Three patterns in the table. T holds at the anchor level in every scored row — provisionally in the pipeline instance, which alone rests on an author-attested freeze — and in every row the anchor named is the anchor that carries the claim. One row carries a scoped downgrade: Channel III's arrows are dated [R08]–[R10], but the channel-level priority of the abstract quantity over the physical fails, so the row is scored as a scoped pass and the channel is labeled abstract-quantity/formal-analogy (§4). D is where the honesty of this paper lives: one partial pass with an explicit downgrade to the supply level (Channel I, [R01]); one dispute left unresolved because the claim is invariant under either outcome (Channel II); four indeterminates, where the pool contains no study that could run the check (Channels III and IV, and the two companion chains added at the R5 instance-candidate pass); and one out-of-scope, where indispensability is not what the instance claims (§7) — four dispositions, one dictionary, stated in §1.2. R passes in every scored row: every channel leaves an operative residue — a formal language, a modeling technology, a priced quantity, a vocabulary and an agenda, a machine-checkable ledger; the two R5 companion chains leave, in the same column, a priced bound and a term of art. The last row is not a score: §8 makes no empirical claim, so its cells read not applicable rather than pending — F-C3 is a condition the agenda can fail, not a verdict on evidence in hand.

One limit of the table's bite must be stated plainly: F-C1 demands pairwise separability of the four forms, and each channel carries a small number of flagship cases — the additions of this edition make Channels II and IV two each — plus one instance, so the trigger condition —

Row (section)	T (temporal priority)	D (dispensability)	R (operative residue)
Channel I — formal (§2)	Pass (strong; primary texts [R01], [R02])	Partial pass — downgraded to the supply level ([R01])	Pass (strong)
Channel II — controlled (§3)	Pass	Unresolved by design ([R04], [R05])	Pass
Demon chain — controlled, physics companion (§3.4)	Pass — publication-dated chain: 1871 [R61], 1929 [R62], 1961 [R10]; naming act 1874 [R61]	Indeterminate — no study of alternatives in the pool	Pass (strong) — principle-grade residue ([R10]; experimental line surveyed in [R43])
Channel III — quantitative (§4)	Scoped pass — arrows publication-dated [R08]–[R10]; channel-level priority downgraded (statistical entropy predates the definition by roughly seventy years)	Indeterminate	Pass (strong)
Channel IV — narrative (§5)	Pass (tiered anchors [R11]–[R13])	Indeterminate	Pass
Uncanny-valley chain — narrative companion (§5.2)	Pass — publication-dated chain: 1816 [R58], 1919 [R59], 1970 [R60]	Indeterminate — no study of substitutes in the pool	Pass — operative term of art in human–robot interaction ([R60])
Pipeline instance (§7)	Provisional pass (author-attested freeze; pre-registered tier — §7.4)	Out of scope (no indispensability claim)	Pass
Reverse channel (§8)	Not applicable — §8 asserts no empirical claim; F-C3 is an agenda condition, not a pending verdict	Not applicable	Not applicable

some pair returning identical grade profiles across all scored flagship cases — is close to unmet on formal grounds alone, simply because the specimens are few. This is a limit of the check's current bite, not a pass on separability; F-C4 keeps the typology revisable as cases accrue.

The paper on its own checks. The table above scores the paper's objects; the promise of the section's title — the checks on the paper itself — is kept here, scores reported as they come. *T*: the apparatus was assembled after the cases it scores, so the paper's own construction runs setting-first, not pre-registration-first; what was fixed before distribution is the kill-line list of §9.3, a genuine but narrow pre-commitment. *D*: a partial pass, downgraded to the supply level: the four channels could be re-described in neutral terms (unreferenced formal systems, idealized scenarios, defined quantities, narrative sources) and the checks would survive the re-description; what would not carry over is the apparatus — the checks, the tiers, the disposition dictionary, the mapping — which is why §1.3 orders the apparatus first. *R*: pending, by the check's own definition, since residue is what remains after the encounter and the paper's encounter with its readers has not happened. The paper's self-score is T partial, D partial, R pending. A paper about kill lines that withheld its own would fail M5; a paper that graded itself above what its checks return would fail them more quietly.

9.2 Limitations

Four limitations, stated plainly. Selection effect: the four channels are visible because their cases left anchors; feedback that left no record is invisible to this method, and the typology is a typology of the documented. The same effect reaches the scores: T and R pass in every scored row of §9.1 partly because the cases were selected for anchorability and residue, so those passes are in part a product of case selection rather than an independent finding; D, which the cases were not selected to pass, is where the selection pressure shows least. Scale: each

channel carries a small number of flagship cases, and the pipeline has one engineering-grade instance; the R5 instance-candidate pass (2026-10-20) adds one companion chain each to the controlled and narrative channels — a physics case beside the philosophical stock cases, and a chained-primary-text case beside the lexical and named-textual anchors — extending the anchor forms, not the small-number discipline, and the adjudication structure is unchanged; no prevalence claim is made anywhere in this paper. Magnitude: structural parallel to the non-Euclidean pattern does not make the engineering instance comparable to it in scale (§7.3). Tiers: the historical tier and the pre-registered tier are different instruments, and nothing in §2–§5 borrows the authority of §7's. Two boundary conditions close the list: the reference pool is closed at sixty-six items (§1.3(ii)); and the novelty statements rest on the single-engine, non-systematic retrieval recorded in §1.3(iv), whose protocol and limits are stated in the Appendix. The nearest neighbor that search returned [R42] is a dialogue partner rather than a competitor: it maps the roles fiction plays around technoscience, while this paper scores what fictional inputs do to science, under named checks.

9.3 What would weaken this paper

The falsifiability conditions are re-recorded here, in substance unchanged from §1.2, operational readings included. F-C1: if the four forms prove pairwise inseparable under the three checks — some pair returning identical grade profiles across all scored flagship cases — the typology weakens. F-C2: if a flagship case fails the temporal check — its earliest dated record not earlier than the dated scientific use credited to it — or cannot sustain even the supply-level claim, no primary record carrying an operative residue, its channel is downgraded. F-C3: if machine-generated hypotheses, run under pre-registered adjudication, systematically leave no kill line to hang — in every case of a sample fixed before the run — the reverse channel is declared dead. F-C4: if new cases cannot be classified without ambiguity into one of the four forms under the same three checks — independent classifiers disagreeing, or more than one admissible form persisting — the typology is ad hoc. The mapping of §6 carries its own condition: if any row's two ends fail to share form and failure mode on inspection, the method claim weakens. These are the paper's kill lines, recorded before any reader runs them — because a paper about kill lines that withheld its own would fail M5, the row this paper has least standing to fail. One asymmetry is stated rather than left tacit: F-C2's dispensable-input exemption means a supply-level channel claim can be downgraded but never killed outright by D, so no direct kill line attaches to the supply tier itself.

Three dialogue partners locate the position this paper takes. Fictionalism, in the philosophy of mathematics, asks what it would be for a discourse to be useful yet untrue; this paper asks the flatter question of when a fictional object is used at all, and answers with instruments rather than semantics. The model-based-reasoning tradition in history and philosophy of science studies how idealizations mediate inference; here the mediation is not assumed but scored, one dated case at a time. The historiography of the exact sciences documents episodes; this paper asks each episode to carry a verdict structure on top of the documentation. The three dialogues do not merge, and the paper stands in the space between them rather than inside any one of them. That standing is itself fallible in this paper's own sense: if the channels separate only by the accidents of their anchors, if the disposition dictionary turns out to grade nothing, or if the checks come to seem decoration rather than criteria, the paper dies by the lines it drew for itself. Between the partners, the position is not a synthesis but a boundary: the paper claims the space its instruments can defend, and no more.

The line this paper belongs to ascends in three stations: a practice that carries its own kill verdicts, carried to term in the line's first public work; a loop between worldbuilding and machine cognition, declared in the companion and run here as apparatus; and a mind–matter formulation now in preparation. The stations do not replace one another — the verdict line is the first action at every station, held rather than discarded — and the third station's direction

is offered on the same terms as the first: no exemption, no privilege.

AI use disclosure

The drafting model is GLM, used for drafting and revision support under author instruction. The claims, the criteria, the mapping, and every number were specified by the authors. AI participation went beyond drafting and is stated in full: retrieval, matching, and the entry-by-entry verification of the reference pool ran with machine assistance; the anchor digests and the frozen numbers were re-checked by script; the third-party recomputation of 2026-09-18 recorded in §7.2 was executed by a machine agent rather than a human third party; and the draft was examined by multiple independent rounds of machine review before this revision, with each review finding adjudicated by the authors and its resolution recorded in the revision record rather than silently absorbed. The authors directed all work, adjudicated all findings, and bear full responsibility for the result. No content was generated by the AI without human review. Each number in §7 maps to a field path in the frozen artifact cited in place. Two same-line works are declared in §8.4 — the companion position statement [R57] and a mind–matter formulation in preparation; both issue from the same dialogue-driven research practice stated here, and neither is evidence for the other, nor inherits this paper's guarantees.

Appendix: Verification Statement

Verification records consolidated here, in one place, so that the body of the paper carries one pointer per site.

Pool verification, batch by batch. Fifty-five of the first fifty-six pool entries were verified against primary records. The base pool [R01]–[R41] was verified entry by entry at the first verification pass (title and identifier against a primary record: DOI, arXiv, or venue page). [R13] and [R14] initially carried unstable identifier snapshots and were anchored by primary-source descriptors; both identifiers were closed at the 2026-09-18 deep-revision pass (R13: NTRS Document ID 19940022856; R14: DOI 10.1007/s12369-022-00876-z), so the pool then closed at 55 verified + 1 anonymized ([R56]) = 56. [R42]–[R45], added at the second-round verification pass, carry that pass as their verification record; [R46]–[R52], added at the dual-review source-supplement pass, were verified against publisher-level records; [R53]–[R54], added at the R2 literature-verification pass, were verified against full-text captures retrieved 2026-09-17; [R55] (Helmholtz), added at the R2 full-revision pass, was verified against the full-text capture of the Atkinson translation retrieved 2026-09-17. [R56] is attested by its authors rather than independently verified. Ten entries were added at the R5 passes (2026-10-20), all by declaration, not by protocol search, outside the three-line search of this Appendix: [R57] (the companion position statement of §8.4; its carrier is carried in the public repository at the citation-frozen commit, SHA-256 prefix `1568b3dfe5ae`; attested by its authors rather than independently verified) and [R58]–[R66] (the instance-candidate chain anchors of §§3–5; each verified against primary records at addition by web retrieval on 2026-10-20, with two bibliographic adjudications adopted at terminal check: the [R59] entry's Standard Edition volume, XVIII in the pre-revision draft, was corrected to XVII, the volume of record for the 1917–1919 papers; and the [R60] entry's authorized translation, issued in June 2012 both as an IEEE Spectrum web essay and in the print magazine, is anchored to the journal of record, IEEE Robotics and Automation Magazine 19(2):98–100). The pool now closes at 64 verified + 2 anonymized ([R56], [R57]) = 66.

Retrieval protocol and screening rule. The three-line search of §1.3(iv), completed 2026-09-16, ran sixty-four query groups on a single commercial web-search engine: a pool-item line locating the anchor entries (twenty-three title-level queries), an identifier line re-verifying them against DOI, arXiv, and venue records (fourteen queries), and an adjudication/novelty line covering case-provenance and adjacent-literature look-ups (twenty-seven queries); the raw

retrieval snapshots (five results per query) are retained in the project's literature line and are available from the author on request in this edition, under the availability terms stated below. Screening rule: no candidate enters the pool without first-hand verification of its title and identifier against a primary record; an entry without a stable identifier is omitted rather than kept. The record is a single-engine, non-systematic sweep, not a multi-database survey; the uniqueness statements say what this search returned, not what the literature at large contains, and the record's limits are inherited by every statement made relative to it.

[R36] capture limit. The anthologies that frame the modern hard-SF canon [R36] exemplify the tradition the genre's reference entry describes. Their framing is used as paraphrase, not quotation: the anthology's full text was not captured in the verification pass, so [R36] carries no direct quotation anywhere in this paper, and the limit is flagged here rather than papered over.

Row-by-row provenance, stated in full. M1's claim–support correspondence has its argumentation-theoretic original in Toulmin's layout of claims, data, and warrants [R46] — a theory of argument rather than a methodology paper, mounted with that genre declared. M2's no-future-capability demand restates the speculation critique of [R39] in criterion form. The pre-registration clauses of M4 stand on the preregistration revolution [R47] and the Registered Reports model [R48]; the third-party recomputation clause stands on the NeurIPS reproducibility program [R49] and the cross-disciplinary policy statement on computational reproducibility [R50]; the falsifiability and kill-line clauses of M5 stand on Popper's demarcation criterion [R51] and its working application to machine-learning interpretability research [R52]. M3's anchoring criterion claims no pool original; it is this paper's formalization outright. The failure modes are those of [R38] and [R39]; the criteria that catch them are this paper's.

Availability terms. The frozen record is public: the five pre-registration anchors (Table 1), the measured-field artifacts of Tables 2 and 3, the archived source markdown that carries the handoff record's fields (`_september_workspace/results/_archive_2026_09_20/fiction_that_feeds_back_source.md`), and the third-party recompute record of §7.2 are deposited in the public repository `https://github.com/zeroandcat/Deposon` at commit `a57d7fe` — the citation-frozen commit: every content citation in this edition resolves at that commit, and later repository history does not affect them. The full SHA-256 digests — not only the twelve-character prefixes printed in §7 — are reproducible from the repository's files at that commit. The repository additionally archives an earlier, 23-page edition of this paper (`_september_workspace/results/_archive_2026_09_20/fiction_that_feeds_back.pdf`, 356,123 bytes, SHA-256 prefix `2d9edc8c7303`); this revised edition supersedes that archived edition, and no measurement artifact differs between the two — the supersession touches only the paper's own text. Both formerly declared gaps are closed: the handoff record's machine-readable carrier was deposited at commit `9b6d80a` (SHA-256 prefix `9fccd007be9f`; 2026-09-29, repository root) and the 2026-08-30 audit record at commit `3eee223` (SHA-256 prefix `ed5eb708f332`; 2026-09-30, `_september_workspace/results/AUDIT_2026-08-30.json`, since relocated under the repository's mirror prefix with bytes unchanged). Both depositions post-date the citation-frozen commit and are cited at their own deposition commits; the digests this paper relies on refer to the bytes as deposited. The raw retrieval snapshots of the Appendix's search record, retained in the project's literature line rather than in the repository, are available from the author on request. Whether the public availability is taken up is outside the authors' control and is not claimed to have occurred beyond the third-party recomputation of 2026-09-18 recorded in §7.2.

Anchor standing. The §7 instance's temporal anchor is an author-attested freeze: a digest attests that the artifact was not altered after the fact, but from inside the record it cannot, to a party that did not build the system, attest that the freeze preceded the runs; that ordering is recorded by the artifact and its protocol, the builders' own. The upgrade path — trusted time-stamp, third-party archive, recomputation — is half executed: an independent third-party

recomputation (2026-09-18) verified anchors and headline numbers, while time-stamping and archiving have not occurred. T remains a provisional pass accordingly (§7.4).

References

The reference list is the closed pool of sixty-six items, cited in the text by pool number [R01]–[R66]. Pool numbers count entries, not works: [R12] carries two primary texts under one entry. Two entries, [R56] and [R57], are the authors' companion works, anonymized in this edition (title, authors, and identifiers withheld; to be restored in a later revised edition; [R56] available to any reader from the author on request; [R57] carried in the public repository at the citation-frozen commit; both attested by the authors rather than independently verified). Entries [R58]–[R66] were added at the R5 instance-candidate pass (2026-10-20) by declaration, not by protocol search — they enter outside the three-line search protocol, and the search-relative statements of §1.3(iv) are unaffected; each was verified against primary records at addition. Entries are transcribed at the granularity of the verification record: titles appear where the record carries them.

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Pool R58–R66 (adjunct to §3, §5; added at the R5 instance-candidate pass, 2026-10-20; by declaration, not retrieval — outside the three-line search of the Appendix; entries may carry multiple texts of one chain, following the [R12] precedent)

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